



FITNESSWISE

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Making the calendar fit the athlete

Why it's time to challenge the rigidity of traditional periodisation models, and design training models that **adapts** to the athlete, not the calendar.

“Stay committed to your decisions but stay flexible in your approach.” — Tony Robbins

Human adaptation does not follow calendar schedules drawn up according to someone's research somewhere.

Individual recovery capability varies dramatically between athletes, depending on numerous variables. Individual physiology determines readiness, not a pedantic weekly planner. The periodised model is merely a tool — it cannot be followed verbatim for all athletes.

Bespoke training blocks, designed in tandem with multiple variables, yield the best results. Here's something that might make every sports science graduate slightly uncomfortable when it comes to periodisation. The traditional periodisation model we've been teaching for decades can, and perhaps should, be enhanced or modified.

This process is driven by individual strength and conditioning (S&C) coaches responding to the needs of the moment, rather than following an obstinate path. It is especially relevant for RTP (Return to Play) athletes and those recovering from injury, where progression in specialised fitness components must align closely with skill and sport. Microcycles, mesocycles and macrocycles form the foundation of periodisation. They have been an excellent framework for decades but are they foolproof?

Can they be manipulated? That's the big question.

No dates, please

Many believe that all athletes, regardless of variables such as age, genetics, training age, available facilities, dietary discipline, recovery ability, stress levels, or lifestyle history, will somehow adapt to training loads neatly within a week, ready for progression immediately.

This is, frankly, pious claptrap.

Some athletes may adapt to a training block within seven days; others might need 10 to 15. A 16-year-old and a 24-year-old do not operate on the same biological timeline simply because they're both available for training immediately. An athlete juggling school and exams, or any other stress, cannot recover at the same rate as one whose life is stable and stress-free.

Yet athletes are forced into arbitrary time compartments. Inevitably, some will plateau or break down while others thrive.